Paes writes that Krishnadevaraya starts his day with a 350 ml drink of seed oil, rubs it all over his body and does weightlifting, wrestling, fencing and horse riding. A Brahmin bathes the king, after which the latter does puja and then begin his courtly duties. His palace is ‘surrounded by a very strong wall’ near which is an unusual temple where they sacrifice ‘every day many sheep’. Down the street from this temple are many fine homes of the rich, including merchants who sell precious stones, textiles, horses and ‘every other sort of thing there is on earth and that you may wish to buy’. The city’s flourishing trade attracts ‘men belonging to every nation and people’, some of whom are even depicted on pillars and other relief sculptures in the city.

Paes visits the Muslim quarter of Vijayanagar where live many Muslim ‘natives of the country and who are paid by the king and belong to his guard’. He climbs a hill for a view of the city and finds it ‘as large as Rome, and very beautiful to the sight’, with its groves of trees, homes with gardens, orchards and lakes. He likely climbed Matanga Hill, which still affords a sweeping view of the city’s ruins and a lovely belt of coconut and banana plantations.

Paes calls Vijayanagar ‘the best provided city in the world’, well stocked with various grains, pulses and other seeds; poultry, mutton, pork, fish; butter, oil, milk; fruits like mangoes, oranges, lime, pomegranates, jackfruit and grapes; and vegetables like brinjals, radishes and others ‘in such abundance as to stupefy one’. Religious sensibilities have clearly changed as today’s traveller finds no meat in the Hampi village, not even in restaurants catering to foreign tourists.

Paes describes a Ganesh temple where ‘they feed the idol every day, for they say that he eats; and when he eats women dance before him’. These women, and the daughters born to them, all belong to the temple, and who, according to Paes, are of ‘loose character’. However, they ‘live in the best streets in the city’, are ‘very much esteemed’, on par with the courtesans of the elite, and ‘any respectable man may go to their houses without any blame attaching thereto’.

The Brahmins of course serve as temple priests but many also work ‘as officers of the towns and cities and belong to the government of them; others are merchants, and others live by their own property and cultivation, and the fruits that grow in their inherited grounds’.